Picketts Valley still having NBN woes

Residents of Picketts Valley are still unable to connect to the internet through the NBN despite all surrounding streets of surrounding suburbs being active since June 19.

Picketts Valley is designated as Fibre To The Node (FTTN), with two nodes servicing the suburb, one near Country View Cls and the other on the Scenic Hwy.

Despite being activated in June, residents have been left in the dark as to when and why they can't access the internet.

Valley resident, Mr Matthew Malone, said the NBN Co had failed to inform residents about when the lines would be quality tested and said there had been no updates on the state of the Valley's NBN service other than that it would be ready by October 2016.

"Picketts Valley is a semi-rural suburb of the Central Coast region of New South Wales.

"The area has never had any reliable access to the internet, as it is 5km away from the Avoca Beach exchange and up until the NBN, expensive 3G mobile internet has been the only option for residents to have internet access," Mr Malone said.

Mr Malone also said residents were left in a state of confusion thanks to NBN Co's back flipping over the status of their area's rollout.

"The way in which NBN Co has communicated the rollout in the Valley has caused widespread confusion.

"Their online status page has flip-flopped between active and inactive many times.

"Calling NBN Co yields absolutely zero additional information, other than a scripted 'we are working on it.'

"NBN Co's website states that the area is ready for service and that we should contact our service providers, but when we do, we are told that the NBN is not ready yet.

"NBN Co's website has now returned to stating that additional work is required," Mr Malone said.

The question of just how much work is needed to get Picketts Valley online remains unknown, despite the fact that remedial works were performed on both nodes throughout July and August.

Adding to residents' frustration is the possibility that the network will not generate speeds at a reliable or fast rate and that further upgrades will come at their own expense.

According to Mr Malone, the Country View node connects to the existing copper network via an underground hub and then an aerial connection, before crossing the road (underground again) to the power pole opposite number 71.

This means that there is an additional 230 metres of copper between the node and the start of the connection.

"Many residents have expressed the need for FTTP (Fibre To The Premises).

"NBN Co, offers a 'Technology Choice' service to change an individual premise over, at their expense (costing anywhere between $1-15,000).

"However, this option can only be started once the area has been activated.

"It is also likely that a brand new fibre line will need to be brought in the existing FTTN infrastructure," Mr Malone said.

The lack of information coupled with the fear that the service won't live up to expectations has residents particularly upset, as the NBN was touted as the 'be all end all' of the Valley's internet connectivity woes.

According to Mr Malone, the lack of a dedicated, reliable and affordable internet service was taking its toll on the inhabitants of Picketts Valley, many of which were business owners forking out massive sums to keep their businesses online through 3G.

"Residents of Picketts Valley have been in constant contact with NBN Co.

"We have had multiple ongoing investigations with them as to why there have been delays.

"Local Member, Lucy Wicks, was able to give us a higher level contact at NBN Co that reviewed our case.

"Unfortunately they had to cancel our investigation because they noted that the area was still 'under construction', and no further information on when the area will be activated was available," Mr Malone said.

Fed up with the NBN Co's response, Mr Malone has created a community website for the residents of Picketts Valley (www.picketts.com.au) to summarise the community's ongoing issues with the NBN Co and outline the situation as it develops.

"I created the website out of sheer frustration, no other method was getting through to the appropriate people and I needed somewhere central to help communicate any updates I received to the other residents," Mr Malone said.

Mr Malone urges other residents of Picketts Valley as well as the surrounding suburbs slated into the Valley's rollout (Kincumber, Kincumber South, North Avoca, and Avoca Beach) to follow the issue.

Email, Sep 5, 2016
Matthew Malone, Picketts Valley
Interview, Sep 5, 2016
Matthew Malone, Picketts Valley

Revitalisation of the Central Coast Leagues Club is about to begin

After a complete rework of its renovation plans, the revitalisation of the Central Coast Leagues Club is about to begin.

The Board has thanked the club's many members for their patience while the club revisited its renovations, originally intended to commence in March 2016.

The Directors decided to re-visit the original plans with a view to including additional works, if financially possible.

The reworked plans have increased the scope of the renovations to ensure the entire ground floor would be renovated, with all gaming, bar and most food outlets on the one level.

The ensuing works will enable the club to completely revamp the ground floor into a member-friendly area with additional dining and family friendly spaces together with new bars, TAB and reception areas, according to the directors.

The concept is to provide a high-quality venue that maintains all of the features that the members and visitors love about the club, a statement from the directors said.

A project manager has been appointed and it is now envisaged that work will commence in October, with dates published online and within the Club.

"Renovating the appearance of the club is just the first step, as the board is also reviewing all aspects of the Club's operations, including the quality of their products and a review of their current promotions, entertainment and events", said Chairman, Mr Peter James.

Changes will not be made in isolation, as the club has already conducted several focus groups with members, engaged secret shoppers, liaised with members on the floor and obtained information through questionnaires.

"We have spent a great deal of time working with the builders on the staging of the work to ensure that throughout the construction process, the impact on members is kept to a minimum", Mr James said.

"Commencement is expected in October with completion in March 2017.

"Once completed, I am sure that the new facilities will provide members with a new and vibrant family friendly environment with which to enjoy club life", said Mr James.

With the resignation of the General Manager, Mr John Keene, the business has been maintained both while John was on leave and now, by the Acting General Manager, Mr Peter Blacker.

Mr Blacker brings considerable club and business experience to the position.

The Board will be addressing a more permanent solution in the coming months.

Central Coast Leagues Club and its staff would like to thank John Keene for his contribution to the Club during his long term of employment.

Much time has been spent by the Board improving its governance standards with directors attending mandatory education courses during the year, improving meeting procedures and ensuring robust decision making processes are in place.

This will ensure directors have the knowledge and information necessary when planning the future of the club.

Media release,
Sep 14, 2016
Peter James, Central Coast Leagues Club

Independent technical consultant appointed for landfill site

The NSW Environment Protection Authority (EPA), in consultation with Mountain Districts Association representatives, has appointed a technical consultant to provide information and independent advice on the Verde Terra landfill at Mangrove Mountain.

EPA Executive Director of Waste and Resource Recovery, Mr Steve Beaman, said the appointment of the consultant, Mr Alan Dyer, from SLR Consulting, provided a resource for the community association around the review of management plans for the site that will inform the EPA's licence review process.

"The EPA has been meeting with community members since last year to discuss their concerns about the Verde Terra site and to reinforce that the EPA will be undertaking a robust review of the proposal.

"As part of those discussions, the EPA committed to make available an external expert, chosen by the community, to provide them and the EPA with independent advice on this matter.

"This will include advice on the proposed management plans from the operators, including landfill plans, engineering design and proposed water quality management and monitoring regimes."

In 2014 the Land and Environment Court granted continued operation of the landfill site in accordance with updated environmental management plans.

The consultant will interpret technical information for the community, provide advice, and will also prepare a report for the EPA on his findings.

The first meeting between the EPA, the Mountain Districts Association representatives and the independent expert, Mr Alan Dyer, was held on Wednesday, September 14.

Media release,
Sep 14, 2016
Emily Boyle, Environment Protection Authority